Speculative campaign response. Not affiliated with or commissioned by Costa Coffee. All figures come from public sources, cited in Harvard style. Where I've had to assume something, the text says so.

CAMPAIGN PLAN · UK · 12-WEEK ACTIVATION

Take Five: winning back Costa's weekday afternoon

For the first time in nearly two decades, Costa is not the UK's largest branded coffee operator. This plan doesn't try to out-discount Greggs or out-craft the independents. It goes after one occasion Costa can realistically own: the 2–5pm weekday break.

Prepared by Vedansh Dubey · September 2026 · Around 10 pages plus executions

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01 · SITUATION

A growing market that Costa is not growing with

Allegra World Coffee Portal's *Project Café UK 2026* counts Greggs at 2,737 UK branded coffee outlets and Costa at 2,707. That is the first time the bakery chain has led. Each holds about 22% of the market (Allegra World Coffee Portal, 2026a; 2026b). Costa last changed position in 2007, when it overtook Starbucks (Allegra World Coffee Portal, 2026c). Starbucks is third with 1,424 outlets (Searles, 2026).

Figure 1. UK branded coffee outlets by operator, Project Café UK 2026



Source: Allegra World Coffee Portal (2026a); Searles (2026). Outlet definitions differ by source. Greggs reports 2,739 shops at 27 December 2025 (Greggs plc, 2026), and Costa is quoted elsewhere at "around 2,600" UK cafés (Nicholls, 2026) and "2,800 stores" (The Grocer, 2026a). This plan uses Allegra's figures throughout so the comparisons are like for like.

The financial picture

Costa Limited's accounts for the year to 31 December 2024, filed at Companies House on 30 December 2025, show revenue up 1% to about £1.2bn (£1.23bn against £1.22bn). The operating loss widened from £5.8m to £13.5m, which is more than double (Companies House, 2025; Houlton, 2026; Nicholls, 2026). The company put the loss down to "soft footfall and growth of value-led competitors" (Houlton, 2026). A £67m profit after tax came mostly from £85m of dividend income, not from trading (Nicholls, 2026). Before 2020, Costa regularly made annual operating profits of £60m–£100m (Houlton, 2026).

£6.8bn
UK branded coffee shop market, 2025, up 5.5% in value
Allegra WCP, 2026a; Searles, 2026

12,313
Outlets, up 3.5%: 420 net new in 12 months
Allegra WCP, 2026a

£13.5m
Costa operating loss, FY2024 (FY2023: £5.8m)
Companies House, 2025

#1
Greggs' YouGov BrandIndex rank for value and consideration, 2025
Greggs plc, 2026

Polarisation

Allegra describes "growing polarisation between affordable and high-end operators", along with a new group of on-trend brands built on iced drinks, matcha and more upmarket hospitality (Allegra World Coffee Portal, 2026a). Both ends of the market are growing:

- **Value.** Greggs' 2025 sales rose 6.8% to £2.15bn. It gained share of food-to-go visits in a market where visits fell 3.1%, and it says it is the number one food-to-go brand for value (Greggs plc,

2026). A medium black Americano was reported at £1.80 at Greggs and £1.79 at McDonald's, against £4.20 at Costa (Comunicaffè, 2026). Prices vary by location, so treat these as indicative.

- **Premium.** Gail's revenue grew 20% to £278m in the year to February 2025, with 40 more bakeries planned (The Grocer, 2025b). Gail's, Pret, Black Sheep Coffee and The Coffee House all grew their estates by double digits (Allegra World Coffee Portal, 2026b).

Figure 2. Reported price of a medium black Americano, 2026



Source: Comunicaffè (2026). These are single reported prices, not audited national averages. Prices vary by store and region.

Costa's own response

Costa is refreshing what it already has, not expanding fast. It launched matcha and new cold drinks in all stores in January 2026 (The Grocer, 2026a). It plans about fifty new openings (Comunicaffè, 2026), including up to 40 drive-thrus, and is spending £3.5m on new and refurbished London stores built for "longer dwell time" (The Grocer, 2026b). It has also signed a ten-year deal to replace Starbucks in up to 26 Cineworld cinemas (The Grocer, 2026c). One asset hasn't moved: Costa was voted the Nation's Favourite Coffee Shop for the sixteenth year running in Allegra's survey of more than 5,000 consumers (Comunicaffè, 2026).

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02 · THE PROBLEM

The problem in one sentence

> Costa is a trusted, well-liked brand that no longer gives people a clear reason to choose it, in a market that now rewards either cheapness or craft.

That problem has two parts. The first is **price and cost structure**. A £4.20 Americano can't compete with an £1.80 one, and a marketing campaign can't change that. It is a question for pricing, property and operations. The second is **perception and occasion**. Costa has no single

moment of the day that people naturally think of as a Costa moment. Greggs owns breakfast (it is number one at breakfast; Greggs plc, 2026). Independents and Gail's own the weekend treat and the story behind the product.

This plan works on the second part only. It gives Costa one ownable, measurable occasion, the weekday afternoon, and uses loyalty to add value without cutting menu prices.

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03 · OBJECTIVE

One number, openly assumed

> Increase weekday 2–5pm transactions in Costa company-owned UK stores by 6% over a 12-week campaign, compared with a matched prior period and adjusted against a control group of stores.

Why 6%, and why it's a modest target

Meaningful Vision's footfall data puts 28% of UK coffee shop visits in the 3–6pm window. It is the sector's fastest-growing daypart, and total coffee shop visits grew 4% year on year (Meaningful Vision, 2025). If Costa's 2–5pm share is similar, at roughly 25–30% of weekday transactions, a 6% lift in the afternoon equals only about **1.5–1.8% more transactions across the whole weekday**. That is ambitious enough to matter and small enough to be believable. It also sits within a daypart that is already growing for the category, so the campaign is going with market demand rather than against it.

Assumptions I'd need the business to confirm

ASSUMPTION	WHAT I'D NEED FROM COSTA
2–5pm is 25–30% of weekday transactions in company-owned stores	EPOS transactions by hour, by store, for the last 24 months
Afternoon seats are under-used, so the marginal cost of an extra afternoon sale is low	Occupancy or dwell data by hour, and labour scheduling by daypart
Costa Club can target and track afternoon behaviour	Active member base, share of transactions scanned, and push opt-in rate
Enough stores can be matched as a clean control group	Store attributes (format, location type, trading history) to build matched pairs
The sale is incremental, not moved from other times of day	Whole-day transactions for the same customers (via Costa Club IDs)

Franchised, Costa Express, drive-thru-only and Cineworld sites are left out of the primary measure. Including them would make it harder to see what the campaign caused. They still receive creative and assets (see section 8).

04 · AUDIENCE

An occasion, not a demographic

This plan targets a moment, not an age band: **the 2–5pm weekday gap between lunch and the commute home**. At that time of day, people aren't mainly buying caffeine. They're buying one of three things:

The break

"I need fifteen minutes away from my screen." Hybrid and office workers near town centres and business parks.

The meeting spot

"Somewhere neutral with a table." Freelancers, 1:1s, parents after school pick-up, catch-ups.

The reset

"A small treat to get me through to 6pm." Iced drinks and matcha, which skew younger.

Why this is Costa's gap

- **Afternoon demand is rising.** 3–6pm is the fastest-growing daypart for coffee shops and bakeries (Meaningful Vision, 2025). Caffè Nero's UK iced drink sales rose 49% year on year in summer 2025, and it sold 1.3 million matcha drinks in a single quarter (The Grocer, 2025a).
- **Greggs is weaker here.** By Greggs' own Circana data it is number one at breakfast, number two at lunch but only **number three for snacking** (Greggs plc, 2026). It is set up for food to go, not

for sitting down.

- **Independents do this well but can't do it everywhere.** They're good at unhurried afternoons but can't offer them in 2,700 locations.
- **Costa already has what the occasion needs:** seats, a new store format designed for "longer dwell time" (The Grocer, 2026b), a matcha and cold drinks range (The Grocer, 2026a), and the warmth of being the Nation's Favourite Coffee Shop (Comunicaffè, 2026).

Who we are *not* targeting

We are not targeting people choosing on price alone. They're Greggs' customers, and competing for them means a price war Costa would lose. We are also not targeting specialty coffee enthusiasts. They'll judge Costa on craft credentials a campaign can't fix.

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05 · CREATIVE PLATFORM

Take Five.

Tension

People need a break most in the afternoon, and that's also when they feel least entitled to take one. The morning coffee is routine. An afternoon break feels like skiving.

Insight

People don't need a reason to drink coffee at 3pm. They need *permission* to stop for a few minutes.

How I got there

ROUTE CONSIDERED	WHY IT WAS REJECTED
"Costa O'Clock"	Claims a time but not a feeling. It also reads like a happy-hour discount, which trains customers to expect lower prices.
"The Afternoon Reset"	Accurate but generic. Any coffee brand could say it, so Costa can't own it.
"Stay a While"	Sets Costa against speed, which conflicts with drive-thru, click-and-collect and Costa Express, where most growth sits.
"Take Five"	**Chosen.** It's an everyday phrase for a short break. It echoes the 2–5pm window without spelling it out. It works as a call to action, a loyalty mechanic and a caption. And it fits dine-in, takeaway and drive-thru equally well.

> Take Five. Between two and five, stop for five.

How the idea works in practice

- **Product proof:** iced drinks and matcha as the hero products, plus a "Take Five pairing" of a drink with a small sweet or savoury bite. The pairing price would be set by the pricing team within existing limited-time offer rules. This plan doesn't propose a price.
- **Value without discounting:** *Take Five Beans*. Costa Club members earn a bonus bean on any weekday purchase between 2pm and 5pm, so the free drink arrives sooner. The reward is funded from spare afternoon capacity, and the menu price doesn't change.
- **Tone:** warm, lightly funny and on the customer's side. The afternoon slump is the shared enemy; the customer isn't being lectured.

Brand check: the idea needs to steer clear of KitKat's long-established "Have a break" territory. Using the specific number, time window and reward mechanic keeps "Take Five" distinct. Legal should run a trade mark search before development.

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06 · CHANNEL PLAN

Where the money goes

Assumption: a notional total of **£2.5m** covering working media, production and reward funding for a 12-week burst. The percentages are the recommendation. The absolute figures scale with whatever budget is actually approved.

CHANNEL	SHARE	£ (NOTIONAL)	WHY THIS SHARE
Paid social TikTok, Instagram Reels, Snapchat	26%	650k	The main way to reach people during the afternoon, and the only channel that can be scheduled for 1:30–4:30pm scrolling. Kept brand-led to meet the new online rules on advertising less healthy food (see below).
OOH near stores Digital six-sheets, bus shelters, roadside near drive-thrus	22%	550k	Reaches people within walking distance at the moment they're deciding. Digital panels can run only in the afternoon and show a live "it's 3:12" message. Outdoor posters aren't covered by the TV and online restrictions.
Loyalty CRM Costa Club app, push, in-app, email, bonus bean funding	20%	500k	This is where the value offer actually lives, so it is not an add-on. It's the most accurately measured channel, it reaches people who already have the app, and it's how we'll see whether the extra visits are genuinely new. Greggs shows the model works: its app is now scanned in 26.7% of transactions, up from 20.1% (Greggs plc, 2026).
In-store Windows, menu screens, table talkers, barista briefing	14%	350k	Turns passers-by into customers and gets existing customers to take the pairing. Covers roughly 2,700 sites, including versions for franchise stores and Cineworld.
Creator partnerships Micro-creators: work-from-anywhere, student, local city accounts	12%	300k	Real people showing the "permission to stop" idea in real afternoons works better than a polished brand film. Local creators also make the store locations feel relevant.
Measurement and contingency	6%	150k	Pays for the control-store analysis and brand tracking, and leaves money to move to whatever works at week 6.
TOTAL	100%	2,500K	

Regulatory constraint. Since 5 January 2026, UK paid advertising for "less healthy" food and drink has been banned online at all times and on TV before 9pm. There is an exemption for brand advertising that shows no identifiable less healthy product (Department of Health and Social Care, 2025). Paid creator content counts as advertising. So paid social and creator content will lead with the brand, the occasion and the range, and only show specific products that pass the Nutrient Profiling Model check. Outdoor, in-store and owned channels such as the app can feature specific products, subject to legal sign-off.

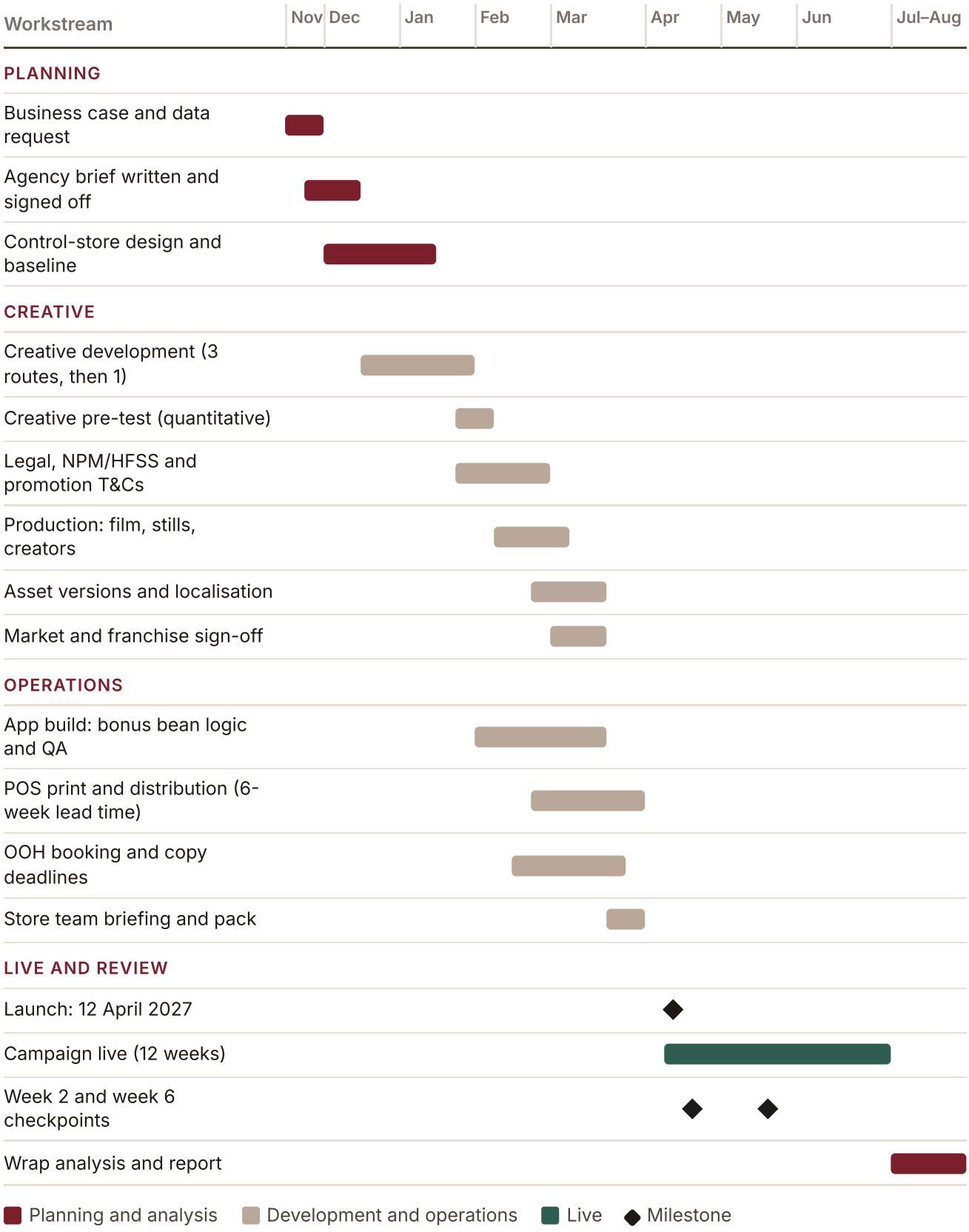
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07 · TIMELINE

From brief to wrap report

The campaign goes live on **Monday 12 April 2027**, after Easter and at the start of the iced drinks season, and runs for 12 weeks to 4 July. Work starts in mid-November 2026. The slow, practical steps are shown in full, because that's where campaigns usually slip.

Figure 3. Campaign Gantt, November 2026 to August 2027 (weekly)



Each column is roughly one week. The Christmas trading freeze (mid-December to early January) is built into the creative development window. POS print lead times are shown as six weeks, which is typical for an estate-wide drop. Confirm this with Costa's print partner.

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08 · ROLLOUT AND BRIEFING

How it reaches every store and market

What the creative brief contains (one page, for the agency)

1. **Background:** the situation in five lines, with sources.
2. **The problem:** the one-sentence problem from section 2.
3. **Objective:** +6% weekday 2–5pm transactions, and how it will be measured.
4. **Audience:** the afternoon occasion and its three jobs (break, meeting spot, reset).
5. **Single-minded proposition:** "Costa gives you permission to take five."
6. **Reasons to believe:** seats and space, the matcha and iced range, Take Five Beans, and 16 years as Nation's Favourite.
7. **Mandatories:** brand guidelines, rules on less healthy food advertising, Costa Club logo lock-up, and promotion T&Cs.
8. **Deliverables:** a list of formats with sizes, durations and versions (see section 10).
9. **Budget, timings and approvers:** who signs off each stage and when.

How markets can adapt it

Markets can adapt some things and not others. That applies to UK nations and regions, franchise partners, Cineworld, and any international Costa market that picks up the platform.

Fixed (cannot change)

- The "Take Five" line and its lock-up
- The afternoon occasion
- Visual system: type, colour and layout grid
- Loyalty mechanic logic
- Legal and nutrition copy

Flexible (market decides)

- Hero drink and food pairing
- Local time and weather references
- Language and idiom (with back-translation)
- Local creators and store addresses
- Media weight and timing within the window

When a market wants to change the creative: it sends a one-page adaptation request explaining what it wants to change, why, and what evidence it has. The central team replies within five

working days with approve, approve with changes, or decline. Anything that changes a fixed element is escalated to the brand lead. If a market adapts well, its version goes into the central asset library for other markets to reuse.

Getting assets to every site

- A single asset hub, such as the existing DAM, with a toolkit filtered by format: company-owned, franchise, drive-thru, Cineworld, Costa Express screen.
- File names show format, size, version and expiry date, for example `TF_D6_1080x1920_Matcha_v3_exp0407`.
- POS arrives as pre-packed store kits with a photo-check: stores upload a photo of their installation by day 3, and the field team follows up with stores that don't.
- A weekly "what's live" email goes to store managers and franchise partners, with a single escalation contact.

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09 · MEASUREMENT

How we'll know, and what we'll do about it

Primary metric: weekday 2–5pm transactions in company-owned test stores compared with the matched prior period. We then subtract the change in matched control stores that get no out-of-home or local social. This is a difference-in-differences design.

Secondary metrics

- Share of afternoon transactions scanned with Costa Club, and new members who sign up during 2–5pm
- Number of different members visiting in the afternoon, and how often they repeat
- Average afternoon transaction value and pairing take-up (to check whether Take Five Beans lowers spend per visit)
- **Cannibalisation check:** whether whole-day transactions per member rise, or morning visits simply move to the afternoon
- Brand: YouGov BrandIndex value and consideration among 18–44s. Greggs leads on both (Greggs plc, 2026)

WHEN	WHAT WE LOOK AT	QUESTION IT ANSWERS
Week 2	POS installed and photographed (target ≥90%), push open rate, bonus bean activations, cost per view and click-through on social	Is it running properly and are people noticing it?
Week 6	Afternoon transactions in test vs control stores, member repeat rate, creative performance by route	Is it working, and what should get more budget?
Week 12	Primary objective, cannibalisation, spend per visit, brand movement	Did it work, and is it worth running again?
Week 16	Afternoon transactions four weeks after the campaign ends	Did people keep the habit, or just take the bonus beans?

Scale it if...

- Test stores are beating control by ≥4% at week 6 and still rising
- Whole-day transactions per member are up, not just moved around
- Spend per visit stays within 3% of baseline

Then: extend to franchise partners, make Take Five Beans permanent, and run a second burst in autumn.

Kill or rework it if...

- Test stores are within ±1% of control at week 6
- More than half of the uplift turns out to be visits moved from the morning
- Bonus bean costs grow faster than the extra margin they bring in

Then: move the contingency budget into loyalty CRM alone, and re-brief the creative.

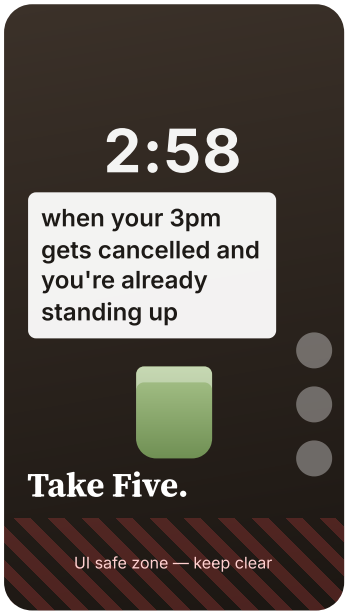
10 · EXECUTIONS

Four formats, four different jobs

These are wireframes showing what each format has to do differently. The finished visuals would be built in Canva to Costa's brand guidelines.

TikTok / Reels frame

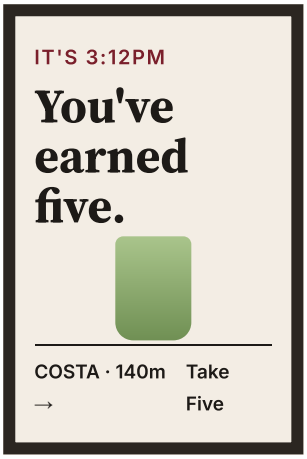
9:16 · 1080×1920 · 9–15s · sound on · brand-led (online food ad rules)



- The hook lands in the first second, set to a native trending sound
- Text sits away from the right rail and bottom caption area
- No identifiable product that fails the nutrient check. The drink is stylised

OOH six-sheet (digital)

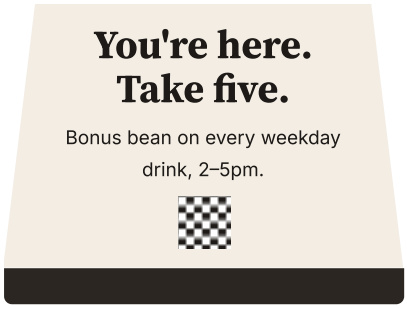
Portrait 1200×1800mm · D6 1080×1920 · runs only 1–5pm · within 500m of a store



- No more than seven words: it has to be read in three seconds
- Live clock and walking distance change per panel
- Specific products allowed here, as outdoor isn't covered by the online and TV ban

In-store table talker

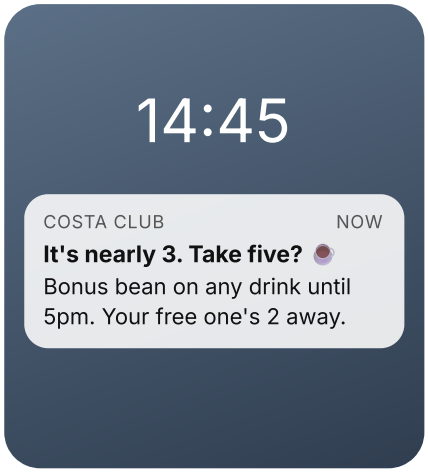
A6 tent card · counter wobbler and window vinyl use the same design



- Its job is to convert people already in store, so it pushes Costa Club sign-up
- The QR code goes straight to app registration
- A franchise version leaves out the loyalty line where the scheme differs

Costa Club app push

Title ≤40 characters · body ≤90 · sent 2:45pm on weekdays · no more than 2 a week



- Personalised with progress towards the member's free drink
- Frequency is capped so people don't opt out
- Timed just before the slump, not in the middle of it

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The original *Project Café UK 2026* report (Allegra World Coffee Portal, London) is subscription-only. The figures above come from Allegra's public summaries and trade press coverage of the report.

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